stone taking the form of *salabhanjika*s that decorate the twelfth-century temples of the Hoysalas in Belur and Halebid in south Karnataka. Pairs of these tree-grasping sprites can also be seen at the entrance gates of many South Indian temples, but now acting as purely decorative guardians.

Many of the Jain immigrants who came south would have been Brahmin by caste but there is no evidence that Vedic Hinduism, whether introduced by Agastya or any other rishi, entered Tamil country before the arrival of Jains at the start of the third century BCE. The earliest surviving literary work that records the presence of Brahmins and the performance of Vedic rites in Tamil country is the poem *Pattinappalai*, written by a Brahmin poet in praise of the Chola king Karikala, dating from the last decades of the second century CE.

The Digambara Jain leader Bhadrabahu and his followers had entered a region dominated by three rival dynasties, whose common ancestor is said to have given birth to three sons known as the Muvendar, or ‘Three Crowned Kings’, all supposedly born at Korkai, near the mouth of the Thamirabarani River. Each brother was too ambitious to be content with sharing power, so the eldest brother, Pandya, stayed put while the other two, Chera and Chola, established their own kingdoms to the north and west respectively. The Cholas went on to rule the country around Thanjavur and Trichy, the Cheras in Travancore and Coimbatore (Kovai), leaving the Pandyas to rule in Madurai and Tirunelveli.